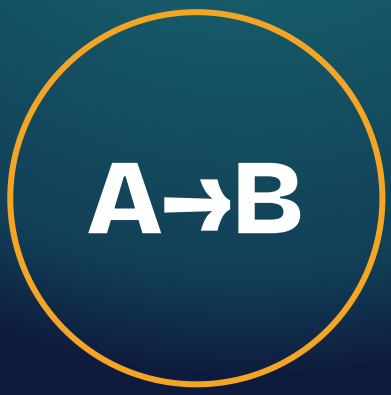
Coaching Codex



COACHING CODEX · GUIDE 17 · NO-CODE AUTOMATION

No-Code Automation Starter Kit: Your First 5 Automations

Connect your apps so busywork does itself, no coding needed: triggers and actions explained, five starter recipes, and tests you check yourself.

5
starter automations, step by step

2
parts to every automation: trigger, action

3
guided tasks: plan, message, test

START HERE

Let your apps do the copy-paste

If you type the same details into two places every day (a web form into a spreadsheet, a finished job into an invoice, a booking into a reminder), a no-code automation can do it for you. This guide explains triggers and actions in plain English, then walks you through five starter automations. AI helps you plan each one from your real facts; you test it with sample data and check every result before it runs for customers.

Trigger
When this happens
A new form entry, a new row, a date, a new email.

Action
Do this
Add a row, draft an email, create a reminder, save a file.

5
Starter recipes
Leads, invoices, reminders, reviews and backups.

What's inside

01	Triggers and actions, explained simply	p. 3
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YOUR FACTS IN, A WORKING RECIPE OUT

AI is good at turning a messy description into clear steps. It does not know your apps, your form fields or your rules. Every prompt here gives AI your confirmed facts, tells it not to invent anything and asks it to check with you when something is missing.

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SECTION 01 · THE BASICS

Triggers and actions, explained simply

Every automation is a sentence: when this happens, do that. The trigger is the event that starts it. The actions are the steps that follow. Most tools also let you add a filter (only continue if...) and a delay (wait two days, then...).

When this happens (trigger)	Do this (action)
Someone submits your website contact form	Add a row to your leads sheet and email you
You mark a job "Done" in your jobs sheet	Create a draft invoice for you to review
It is one day before a booking	Send the customer a reminder
A job has been done for three days	Send one polite review request
An invoice PDF arrives by email	Save it to a cloud folder

Good first candidates

Pick a task you do the same way every time, with the same apps, at least a few times a week. Leave anything that needs judgment (pricing, complaints, refunds) with a person; the automation can still collect the details and alert you.

PROMPT · FIND MY FIRST AUTOMATION

My business: [ONE SENTENCE].
Apps I use every day: [LIST, E.G. WEBSITE FORM, GOOGLE SHEETS, GMAIL, INVOICING APP].
Tasks I repeat by copy-pasting: [LIST 3–5 TASKS, HOW OFTEN].
For each task, write it as "When [TRIGGER], do [ACTIONS]", say whether it needs human judgment, and rank them from easiest to hardest to automate. Use only the apps and tasks I listed. Do not assume features I did not mention. If something is unclear, ask me first.

EXERCISE 1 · YOUR COPY-PASTE LIST (3 MINUTES)

Write three things you copy from one app into another every week, and which apps.

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SECTION 02 · TOOLS

Pick a tool and set it up safely

Start with what you already have: many apps include simple rules or built-in automations. When you need to connect two different apps, use a connector tool. Features, plans, task limits and prices change often, so check the current details before you commit.

Tool type	Examples	Good for	Check first
Built-in rules	Gmail filters, Outlook rules, your booking or invoicing app's reminders	Simple jobs inside one app	Whether it already does what you need
Connector, easiest start	Zapier	Linking popular apps step by step	Which apps connect, plan limits
Connector, visual	Make	Branching flows on a visual map	Operation limits on your plan
Connector, flexible	n8n (cloud or self-hosted)	More control; suits a tech helper	Who maintains and secures it
Chat assistant	ChatGPT, Claude, Gemini, Microsoft Copilot	Planning recipes, writing messages	Never paste passwords or customer data

1. Use a business account you control, with two-step sign-in turned on.
2. Connect each app with the least access it needs; disconnect what you no longer use.
3. Build first with a test copy of your sheet and your own email address as the "customer".
4. Name every automation clearly, for example "Leads: form → sheet + email".

CUSTOMER DATA AND PRIVACY

Automations copy personal data between services. Only move what you need, keep a list of which apps hold customer details, and check each tool's data terms. If you serve people in the UK or EU, GDPR applies to names, emails and phone numbers.

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SECTION 03 · RECIPE 1

Automation 1: capture every lead

The most common first win: every website form entry lands in one leads sheet and you get an alert, so nothing sits unseen in an inbox. Build it once, test it with a fake enquiry, then let it run.

1. Trigger: "New form submission" in your form tool (website form, Google Forms, Typeform or similar).
2. Action 1: "Add row" to your leads sheet. Map each form field to a column: date, name, email, phone, service, message.
3. Action 2: Send yourself an email or chat alert with the name, service and message.
4. Test: submit the form as "Test Lead" with your own email. Check the row and the alert, then delete the test row.
5. Turn it on, and check the sheet daily for the first week.

PROMPT · PLAN MY AUTOMATION RECIPE

Plan a no-code automation for me in **[TOOL]**.
Goal: **[WHAT SHOULD HAPPEN, IN ONE SENTENCE]**.
Trigger app and event: **[E.G. WEBSITE FORM, NEW SUBMISSION]**.
Fields available: **[LIST EXACT FIELD NAMES]**.
Where the data goes: **[SHEET NAME AND EXACT COLUMN NAMES / WHO GETS THE ALERT]**.
Write numbered steps: trigger, each action, which field goes into which column, and a test I can run with fake data. Use only the apps, fields and columns I listed. Do not invent menu names or features; if you are unsure what a menu is called in my tool, say so. If anything is missing, ask me before planning.

MATCH NAMES EXACTLY

Most broken automations come from a renamed column or form field. Copy the exact names into your prompt, and do not rename them later without updating the automation.

SECTION 04 · RECIPE 2

Automation 2: draft invoices for you

When a job is finished, the details already exist in your jobs sheet or booking app. Let the automation create a draft invoice in your invoicing app (for example QuickBooks, Xero or FreshBooks, if your tool connects to it). You review and send it, so a wrong amount never reaches a customer.

Step	What it does	Your check
Trigger	A row's Status changes to "Done"	Status is typed the same way every time
Filter	Only continue if Amount and Customer email are filled in	Empty rows stop here
Action	Create a draft invoice with customer, service, amount and due date	Draft, never auto-send at first
Action	Write the invoice number back into the sheet	You can see what was drafted

PROMPT · CHECK MY INVOICE RECIPE

Here is my planned invoice automation: **[PASTE YOUR STEPS]**.
My jobs sheet columns: **[EXACT COLUMN NAMES]**.
My invoicing rules: **[PAYMENT TERMS, CURRENCY, TAX HANDLING EXACTLY AS MY ACCOUNTANT SET IT]**.
List anything that could create a wrong or duplicate invoice (blank cells, edited rows, a status changed twice) and suggest a filter or check for each. Do not change my amounts, terms or tax settings. If a rule is unclear, ask me first.

MONEY NEEDS A HUMAN

Keep invoices as drafts until the automation has run correctly for a few weeks. Amounts, tax and payment terms come from your records and your accountant, not from AI.

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SECTION 05 · RECIPE 3

Automation 3: send reminders on time

Reminders cut no-shows and late payments without you remembering to send them. First check whether your booking or invoicing app already has reminders built in. If not, a connector can send one from a date column in your sheet or calendar.

1. Trigger: a schedule (every morning at 8:00) or a calendar event starting in 24 hours.
2. Filter: only rows where the date is tomorrow and Reminder sent is empty.
3. Action: send the reminder from your business email, using fields from the row.
4. Action: fill in Reminder sent with today's date, so nobody gets two.

PROMPT · WRITE MY REMINDER TEMPLATE

Write a short, friendly reminder message in **[LANGUAGE]** for my **[BOOKING / PAYMENT]**.
Fields the automation can fill in: **[EXACT FIELD NAMES, E.G. {First name}, {Date}, {Time}, {Address}]**.
Confirmed facts to include: **[E.G. HOW TO RESCHEDULE, CANCELLATION POLICY AS WRITTEN]**.
Under 60 words. Use the fields exactly as written, in curly brackets. Do not invent fees, policies or contact details. If a fact the message needs is missing, ask me before writing.

TEST WITH A FAKE BOOKING

Add a booking for tomorrow under your own name and email, run the automation once, and read the message on your phone. Check that every field filled in and nothing shows as {First name}.

EXERCISE 2 · YOUR REMINDER FACTS

Write what every reminder must say: how to reschedule, what to bring, your policy wording.

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SECTION 06 · RECIPE 4

Automation 4: ask for reviews fairly

A polite request a few days after a finished job is easy to forget and easy to automate. Send one request per job, to every customer the same way, with a direct link to your review page.

Do	Don't
Ask every customer the same way	Only ask customers you think are happy
Send one request, maybe one follow-up	Keep messaging people who did not reply
Link straight to your review page	Offer rewards for positive reviews
Stop if a complaint is open	Write or post reviews for customers

PROMPT · WRITE MY REVIEW REQUEST

Write a short review request in **[LANGUAGE]** for customers of my **[BUSINESS TYPE]**.
Fields the automation can fill in: **[E.G. {First name}, {Service}]**.
Review link: **[YOUR LINK]**.
Sent **[NUMBER]** days after the job. Under 50 words, warm and plain. Ask for an honest review. Do not offer rewards, suggest a star rating or invent details about the job. If anything is missing, ask me first.

REVIEW RULES

In the US, the FTC's rule on fake reviews bans buying reviews and offering rewards only for positive ones. UK and EU consumer law take a similar line, and review platforms have their own rules. Check the current rules for the sites you use.

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SECTION 07 · RECIPE 5

Automation 5: back up important files

Invoices, signed quotes and receipts often live only in an inbox. A backup automation saves each one to a cloud folder (Google Drive, OneDrive or Dropbox) with a clear name, so you can find it at tax time or if an account is locked.

1. Trigger: a new email with an attachment that matches a filter, for example from your supplier or with "Invoice" in the subject.
2. Action: save the attachment to a folder such as Finance / Invoices received / 2026.
3. Name each file the same way, for example Date_Supplier_Invoice-number.
4. Optional: a weekly schedule that saves a dated copy of your leads or jobs sheet.

PROMPT · PLAN MY BACKUP RULE

Plan a backup automation in **[TOOL]**.
Files to save: **[WHICH EMAILS OR FILES, FROM WHOM]**.
Where: **[CLOUD SERVICE AND FOLDER PATH]**.
File naming I want: **[PATTERN]**.
Write the trigger, the filter that catches only these files, and the save step. Also list what would be missed or saved by mistake. Use only what I listed; do not invent senders or folders. If the filter is unclear, ask me first.

A BACKUP IS NOT A BACKUP UNTIL YOU OPEN IT

Once a month, open a few saved files from the folder. If they open and are named correctly, the automation works.

EXERCISE 3 · YOUR FIRST FIVE

Write one sentence for each of your five automations: When ___, do ___.

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SECTION 08 · VERIFY

Test, check, repair and keep it running

Run every automation with fake data before real customers. Check the result in the destination app yourself, not the tool's "success" message, and turn on error alerts so you hear when something stops.

- [ ] A test run with fake data produced exactly the row, draft or message you expected
- [ ] Every field filled in correctly, with no blank or {placeholder} text left
- [ ] Running it twice does not create duplicates (or a filter stops repeats)
- [ ] Messages to customers use only your confirmed facts and policies
- [ ] Error alerts go to an inbox someone reads; you know how to switch it off

PROMPT · FIND WHAT I DIDN'T GIVE YOU

Here are my confirmed facts and rules: **[PASTE FACTS]**
Here is my automated message or recipe: **[PASTE TEXT]**
List every step, field, number, date, policy and claim in the text. Mark each FROM MY FACTS or NOT IN MY FACTS.
Then rewrite the text removing everything marked NOT IN MY FACTS. Do not add anything new.

Check	Pass?	Note
Test run correct		
No duplicates		
Facts match my records		
Error alerts on		

REPAIR PHRASES THAT WORK

For facts: **Replace this assumption with the following confirmed fact: [FACT]. Change nothing else.**
For errors: paste the tool's error message and ask: **Explain this error in plain English and list the likely causes. Do not guess my settings; ask me.**

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FIRST WIN · FICTIONAL EXAMPLE

Your first win, start to finish

Walk through one lead-capture automation for a made-up house-cleaning company in Denver, Colorado. Nothing here is a real business, real people or live AI output.

Example input	Value
Business	Brightside Cleaning (fictional), Denver, Colorado; owner plus three cleaners
Today	Copies each website enquiry by hand from email into a Google Sheet
Tool	Zapier (any connector tool works the same way)
Confirmed facts	Form fields: Name, Email, Phone, Service (Regular clean / Deep clean / Move-out clean), Message · Sheet "Leads" with columns Date, Name, Email, Phone, Service, Message · alert to the owner's email

EXAMPLE COMPLETED PROMPT

Plan a no-code automation for me in Zapier (fictional example for practice).

Goal: Every website enquiry is added to my leads sheet and I get an email alert.
Trigger: My website contact form, new submission.
Form fields: Name, Email, Phone, Service (Regular clean / Deep clean / Move-out clean), Message.
Destination: Google Sheet "Leads", columns Date, Name, Email, Phone, Service, Message. Email alert to me.

Write numbered steps: trigger, each action, which field goes into which column, and a test I can run with fake data. Use only these apps, fields and columns. Do not invent menu names or features. If an essential fact is missing, ask me before planning.

Copy it, open your AI assistant (ChatGPT, Claude, Gemini or Copilot), paste and send. Then compare what you get with this:

ILLUSTRATIVE ANSWER, NOT A LIVE AI RESULT

Before I plan this: which form tool runs your website contact form? Zapier needs to connect to it.
(You reply: "WPForms on my WordPress site.")
1. Trigger: WPForms, new form entry, on your contact form.
2. Action: Google Sheets, create a row in "Leads". Map: submission date → Date, Name → Name, Email → Email, Phone → Phone, Service → Service, Message → Message.
3. Action: Email to you. Subject: New lead: [Name], [Service]. Body: name, email, phone, message.
Test: submit the form as "Test Lead" with your own email, check the new row and the alert, then delete the test row.

Checks before use

- [ ] The AI asked for the missing fact (which form tool) instead of guessing.
- [ ] All six columns are mapped to the right form fields, with exact names.
- [ ] The alert goes to you, not to the customer.
- [ ] Nothing was added: no auto-reply, no extra apps, no invented features.

USE IT

Repair anything not in your facts, build the steps in your tool, run the test with fake data and check the row and alert yourself before turning it on. The webpage does not connect to or change any app.

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GUIDED TASK

Plan your automation recipe

When to use it: You have a task you copy-paste between apps and want clear steps to automate it. **Prepare:** The task as one sentence: when ___, do ___; Exact field and column names; Which connector tool you use.

Question	Example answer
What should happen, in one sentence?	Every website enquiry is added to my leads sheet and I get an email alert
Which automation tool?	Zapier
What starts it (app and event)?	My website contact form, new submission
List the exact fields and where they go.	Form fields: Name, Email, Phone, Service, Message · Google Sheet "Leads": Date, Name, Email, Phone, Service, Message · Email alert to me
Describe your business in one sentence.	A small house-cleaning company in Denver, Colorado

PROMPT TEMPLATE

About my business: [ABOUT YOUR BUSINESS]
Plan a no-code automation for me in [TOOL].
Goal: [GOAL].
Trigger: [TRIGGER].
Fields and destination:
[FIELDS AND DESTINATION]

Write numbered steps: trigger, each action, which field goes into which column, and a test I can run with fake data. Use only the apps, fields and columns I listed. Do not invent menu names or features. If anything is missing, ask me before planning.

ILLUSTRATIVE ANSWER, NOT A LIVE AI RESULT

Which form tool runs your contact form? (Answer: WPForms.) 1. Trigger: WPForms, new entry. 2. Google Sheets, create row in "Leads": date → Date, Name → Name, Email → Email, Phone → Phone, Service → Service, Message → Message. 3. Email to you: "New lead: [Name], [Service]". Test: submit as "Test Lead", check the row and alert, delete the test row.

Checks before use

- [ ] Every field maps to a column that really exists, with the exact name.
- [ ] Only the apps you listed are used.
- [ ] There is a test step with fake data.
- [ ] You answered any questions the AI asked yourself.

Repairs

If...	Send this
Invented or changed a fact	"Replace this assumption with the following confirmed fact: [FACT]. Change nothing else."
Invented a feature	"Remove any step that uses a feature or app I did not list. Mark it [CHECK IN MY TOOL] instead. Change nothing else."
Too technical	"Rewrite the steps in plain English for a beginner, one action per step. Keep every field name exactly as written."

Next action: Build the steps in your tool with a test copy of your sheet, run the test, then turn it on.

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GUIDED TASK

Write an automated customer message

When to use it: Your automation will send a reminder or review request and you need a short, accurate template. **Prepare:** What the message is for; The fields your tool can fill in; Your confirmed policy wording and links.

Question	Example answer
What is the message for?	Reminder the day before a cleaning visit
Which fields can the automation fill in?	{First name}, {Date}, {Time}, {Address}
Paste the confirmed facts it must include.	To reschedule, reply to this email or call 303-555-0142 · Please give at least 24 hours' notice to reschedule · Please clear countertops before we arrive
Describe your business in one sentence.	A small house-cleaning company in Denver, Colorado
Which language should the messages be in?	English

PROMPT TEMPLATE

About my business: [ABOUT YOUR BUSINESS]
Write a short, friendly automated message in [LANGUAGE].
Purpose: [PURPOSE].
Fields the automation fills in: [FIELDS].
Confirmed facts to include:
[YOUR FACTS]

Under 60 words. Use the fields exactly as written, in curly brackets. Do not invent fees, policies, discounts or contact details. If a fact the message needs is missing, ask me before writing.

ILLUSTRATIVE ANSWER, NOT A LIVE AI RESULT

Hi {First name}, a reminder that Brightside Cleaning is visiting {Address} on {Date} at {Time}. Please clear countertops before we arrive. Need to reschedule? Reply to this email or call 303-555-0142, giving at least 24 hours' notice. See you soon!

Checks before use

- [ ] Every field is spelled exactly as in your sheet, in curly brackets.
- [ ] Policy wording and contact details match your records.
- [ ] No fee, discount or promise you did not give.
- [ ] A test send to yourself shows every field filled in.

Repairs

If...	Send this
Invented or changed a fact	"Replace this assumption with the following confirmed fact: [FACT]. Change nothing else."
Field name changed	"Use these field names exactly: [FIELDS]. Change nothing else."
Too long	"Shorten to 40 words. Keep every fact and field exactly as written."

Next action: Paste the checked template into your automation's email step and send one test to yourself.

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GUIDED TASK

Make a test plan and fix errors

When to use it: Your automation is built and you want to test it safely, or it has stopped working. **Prepare:** Your automation's steps; What should happen when it works; Any error message the tool shows.

Question	Example answer
Paste your automation's steps.	1. Trigger: WPForms new entry · 2. Google Sheets: create row in "Leads" · 3. Email alert to me
What should happen when it works?	One new row in Leads with all six columns filled, and one email alert
Any error message or problem? (optional)	Row added but the Phone column is empty

PROMPT TEMPLATE

Here are my automation's steps:
[STEPS]
Expected result: [EXPECTED RESULT].
Problem or error (if any): [ERROR OR PROBLEM]

Write a short test plan using fake data only: what to enter, what to check in each app, and how to spot duplicates. If there is a problem, explain it in plain English and list the likely causes in order. Do not guess my settings; ask me for anything you need to know.

ILLUSTRATIVE ANSWER, NOT A LIVE AI RESULT

Test: submit "Test Lead", test@yourdomain.example, phone 000-000-0000. Check: one new row, six columns filled; one alert. Submit again to confirm one row per entry. Phone empty: likely causes 1) Phone not mapped in step 2, 2) the form field was renamed, 3) Phone is optional on the form and was left blank. Which of these matches your setup?

Checks before use

- [ ] The test uses only fake data and your own email.
- [ ] It checks the result in each app, not just the tool's success message.
- [ ] Likely causes are listed, not stated as certain.
- [ ] You confirmed the fix with a second test run.

Repairs

If...	Send this
Invented or changed a fact	"Replace this assumption with the following confirmed fact: [FACT]. Change nothing else."
Guessed my settings	"Do not assume my settings. Ask me one question at a time to narrow down the cause."
Too technical	"Explain again in plain English, one step at a time, for a beginner."

Next action: Run the test, fix one thing at a time, re-test, and turn on error alerts before going live.

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WHAT'S NEXT

Five automations. Less copy-paste. Every result checked.

Start with the lead capture recipe, test it with fake data, then add invoices, reminders, reviews and backups one at a time. Keep money and judgment with a person, and check each automation's results every week.

AI Spreadsheets for Non-Techies: Formulas, Clean-Up & Reports

Keep the sheets your automations feed clean and useful.

Automate Your Inbox and Customer Replies with AI

Answer the leads your automation captures, faster.

Follow-Up Without Fear: AI Scripts for Quotes, Leads & Win-Backs

Write the follow-ups you can later automate.

Build a 24/7 FAQ Chatbot for Your Website (No Code)

Answer common questions before they become leads.

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